Open Knowledge for a Sustainable Future: Research, Ethics, and Wikipedia

Week 4 — Finding, judging and citing sources

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3. How can I make it easy for my reader?

Roadmap

1. What are good sources?
2. In class: reading each other's writing
3. How can I make it easy for my reader?

Judging a source: the source itself

Ask	You want	Worry if
Who wrote it?	a named author with findable credentials in *this* field	anonymous, or an expert in something else
Who published it?	a journal or press with editors and review	an advocacy group, a content farm, no editorial trail
When?	recent enough for how fast the field moves	stale — or **retracted**
Why was it made?	to report or explain	to sell, to lobby, to entertain

Check retractions in the Retraction Watch Database — by title, DOI, author or journal. It also tells you *why* a paper was withdrawn.

Judging a source: its argument

Ask	You want	Worry if
What is the evidence?	data, examples, citations you can follow	assertions with nothing behind them
Who is missing?	it engages work that disagrees with it	it cites mostly itself and its friends
How is it worded?	measured; states its own limits	loaded words; inconvenient evidence left out
Does it help you?	it supports or challenges *your* claim	it is there to make the bibliography look longer

No source is neutral. Naming the slant is the work; pretending it is not there is the mistake. Evaluation is judgement, not a checklist.

What kind of source is it?

How close to the thing itself

- **Primary**: the data, the text, the interview, the law
- **Secondary**: analysis and interpretation of those
- **Tertiary**: overviews — textbooks, encyclopedias, **Wikipedia**

Who it was written for

- **Scholarly**: peer-reviewed, technical, referenced
- **Popular**: journalism, written to be read over breakfast
- **Grey**: reports from governments, NGOs, companies — often excellent, rarely reviewed

- Use primary for evidence, secondary for framing, tertiary to find your way in
- Wikipedia is where you **start**, not what you **cite** — follow its references to the real sources

The Role of Peer Review

- Peer review adds accountability and expert evaluation.
- Check the journal's own website, or one of these, for peer-review status:
  - DOAJ: free; open-access journals, with their review policy listed
  - Scopus Sources, Web of Science Master Journal List, Ulrichsweb (look for *Refereed: Yes*) — these need a subscription: reach them through the university library, not from home
- Conference papers, reports, and blogs may lack external review.
- Non-reviewed sources can still inform background reading—use carefully.
- Note review processes in your evaluation notes.
  - **Single-blind**: reviewer knows author
  - **Double-blind**: neither reviewer nor author knows the other's identity
  - How many reviewers?

Synthesizing Multiple Sources

- Evaluation continues through comparison.
- Ask:
  - How do sources agree or conflict?
  - Which are most authoritative or current?
- Synthesis reveals gaps and consensus in the field.
- Use evaluation to decide which sources to highlight or challenge.

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In class: read each other's paragraphs

You each read the same three texts on water use in data centres, and wrote three paragraphs. Now swap with the person next to you.

- **Read it once without writing anything** 5 min
- **Then answer four questions on the worksheet** 10 min
  1. What is this writer's **claim**? One sentence, in your own words.
  2. Which text did they **trust most**, and on what grounds?
  3. Do you agree with their **judgement of the sources**?
  4. Do you agree with their **conclusion** about water?
- **Talk in pairs** — start with question 1, and let the writer say whether that is what they meant 10 min

Useful feedback is specific: point at a sentence. "I disagree" is not feedback; "your second paragraph claims X, but the source you cite says Y" is. (worksheet also on the course website)

Questions 3 and 4 are not the same question

- You can think a text is **well evidenced** and still think its **conclusion** is wrong
- You can agree with a conclusion that rests on **nothing**
- Keeping those apart is the whole job:
  - it is what a peer reviewer does in December
  - it is what **neutral point of view** asks of you on Wikipedia: report what the sources say, whatever you think of it

Watch for this in your answers: Masley says data centres use 0.008% of US fresh water. Mytton (2021) and the Wikipedia article talk about stress on *particular* watersheds. Neither is lying. They chose different things to compare against — and that choice does most of the persuading.

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Make the Information Accessible

- 🔍 **Identify the source clearly:** include author, year, title, publisher, and version or edition.
- 📍 **Pinpoint the exact location:** add chapter, section, or page number — especially for long works.
- 🌐 **Help readers find it quickly:** provide a persistent link (URL, DOI) or unique identifier (ISBN, dataset ID).
- 🧭 **Be consistent:** use one style throughout — in this course, **APA 7**.

Avoid Formatting or Mechanics Errors — Why It Matters

- Formal citation styles encode a **“secret code”** —tiny details convey location and source type.
- Using the community’s preferred style is a **“secret handshake”**: it signals you know the insider code.
- Attention to detail builds **credibility** with readers who value intellectual property and accuracy.
- Even in an era of easy keyword search, conventions still help readers **find and verify** sources quickly.
- Goal: demonstrate care and competence, not just avoid penalties.
  - You should use software to help

Pick the Right Style & Identify Source Type

- Different communities prefer different styles: **APA** (most social sciences), **MLA** (literature), **Chicago** (notes-bibliography, or author–date).
  - **For your paper in this course: APA 7.** Examples on the course website.
- Determine what you're citing:
  - Book vs. journal article vs. whole website vs. a single post/section.
  - Each type has **slightly different** required elements and order.
- Differences usually make sense: books have titles/pages; tweets usually do not.
- Match the pattern to the **actual source features**.
- Avoid adding **unnecessary information**.

Same four references, two styles

APA 7 (this course)

Allosso, D., & Allosso, S. F. (2019). *A short handbook for writing essays in the humanities and social sciences*. Minnesota Libraries Publishing Project. https://mlpp.pressbooks.pub/writinghandbook/

Čapek, K. (1936). *Válka s mloky [War with the newts]*. Fr. Borový.

Mytton, D. (2021). Data centre water consumption. *npj Clean Water*, *4*(1), 11. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41545-021-00101-w

Reid, E. S. (2024). *Rethinking your writing: Rhetoric for reflective writers*. The WAC Clearinghouse; University Press of Colorado. https://doi.org/10.37514/PRA-B.2024.2265

ACL (computational linguistics)

Dan Allosso and S. F. Allosso. 2019. *A Short Handbook for Writing Essays in the Humanities and Social Sciences*. Minnesota Libraries Publishing Project.

Karel Čapek. 1936. *Válka s mloky [War with the Newts]*. Fr. Borový, Praha.

David Mytton. 2021. Data centre water consumption. *npj Clean Water*, 4(1):11.

E. Shelley Reid. 2024. *Rethinking Your Writing: Rhetoric for Reflective Writers*. The WAC Clearinghouse; University Press of Colorado.

The software does the formatting

You type each reference **once**, in a `.bib` file:

```
@article{Mytton2021,
  author  = {Mytton, David},
  title   = {Data centre water consumption},
  journal = {npj Clean Water},
  volume  = {4}, number = {1}, pages = {11}, year = {2021},
  doi     = {10.1038/s41545-021-00101-w}}
```

Then you choose the style:

```
\usepackage[style=apa]{biblatex}      % APA 7
\bibliographystyle{acl_natbib}        % ACL
```

- Full names or initials, year first or second, sentence or title case, DOI shown or linked: all decided by the style, not by you
- Zotero does the same in Word: pick a different style from a menu

Consistency is Non-Negotiable

- Pick a style and **stay with it**—don't mix conventions.
- If you sometimes include the year and sometimes don't, readers may suspect **incomplete acknowledgment**.
- For unusual sources (e.g., a deleted TikTok under a pseudonym), imitate the **closest established pattern**.
- Prioritize reader orientation: can they **find** what you cited?
- Keep a short **personal checklist** to enforce uniformity.

Tools Help—But You're Still Responsible

- Bibliography managers and library export tools can **misformat** elements.
  - E.g. Nurril Hirfana binte Mohamed Noor, Suerya binte Sapuan and Francis Bond (2011) cite as Nurril Hirfana, Suerya and Bond (2011)
    binte means "daughter of"
- You must still **proofread** citations against the style rules.
- Learn enough of the code to **spot errors** quickly.
- Online forms may omit fields or guess wrong—**verify** and fill gaps.
- Working in a "**generation gap**" means tools + human judgment are both needed.

Don’t worry too much!

- No one is born knowing citation mechanics; even strong writers make mistakes.
- The most important thing is that people can find the information.
- Errors **do not** imply bad faith—but accuracy **does** build trust.
- Getting the details right gives you **credibility**.
- Over time, you join the discourse community that **evolves** conventions.
- Learn the secret handshake, but most importantly **help readers** locate the sources.

Citing Works Not in English

- Scholarly writing often involves **sources in other languages**.
- Goals:
  - Give credit to the original author.
  - Help readers identify the work (even if they don't read the language).
  - Follow your citation style's rules for **non-English titles**.
- APA and most citation systems recommend:
  - Keeping the original title in the source language.
  - Optionally providing an **English translation in brackets**.
- Transliterate non-Latin scripts if possible; retain diacritics accurately.

General Principles (APA / biblatex)

- Use the author's name in the script of publication (APA allows Latin transliteration).
- Give publication data exactly as printed (year, publisher). APA 7 dropped the publisher's location.
- If the reader is unlikely to understand the title:
  - Add a translation in square brackets, outside the italics: *Válka s Mloky* [War with the Newts].
- Don't invent English titles — translate accurately but informally.
- If the work has an official English edition, you may cite that instead or alongside.

Example: Czech Source (Čapek, 1936)

```
@book{capek1936,
  author    = {Čapek, Karel},
  year      = {1936},
  title     = {Válka s Mloky [War with the Newts]},
  publisher = {Fr. Borový},
  langid    = {czech}
}
```

Text citation examples:

- Čapek (1936) satirizes industrial modernity through the figure of the salamander.
- The allegory of human exploitation appears early in the narrative (Čapek, 1936).

References entry (APA style):

> *Čapek, K. (1936). Válka s Mloky [War with the Newts]. Fr. Borový.*

No place of publication: APA 7 dropped it. Put the translation in the `title` field — biblatex has a `titleaddon` field, but this style brackets it for you, so typing your own brackets there gives you two sets.

Example: Japanese Source (芥川龍之介, 1918)

```
@article{akutagawa1918,
    author = {芥川龍之介},     sortname = {Akutagawa, Ryūnosuke},
    year = {1918},
    title = {蜘蛛の糸 Kumo no ito [The Spider's Thread]},
    journaltitle = {赤い鳥 Akai Tori},
    volume = {1}, number = {1},
    langid = {japanese}}
```

Text citation examples:

- 芥川龍之介 (1918) retells a Buddhist parable of redemption and failure.
- Compassion and egoism intertwine in 「蜘蛛の糸」 (芥川龍之介, 1918).

References entry (APA 7):

> 芥川龍之介 *[Akutagawa, R.]. (1918).* 蜘蛛の糸 *Kumo no ito [The spider's thread].* 赤い鳥 *Akai Tori, 1(1).*

When to Translate or Transliterate

- If the audience reads the language → keep original title only.
- If not → add translation in brackets after the original title.
- Transliteration (romaji, pinyin, etc.) helps with alphabetization and search.
- Example (Japanese romanization):
  Akutagawa, Ryūnosuke. (1918). Kumo no ito [The spider's thread].
- Always apply one consistent pattern for all non-English items.

Acknowledgements I

- The first sections were based on A Short Handbook for Writing Essays in the Humanities and Social Sciences (Allosso & Allosso, 2019)
- I also consulted Reid (2024) and Krause (2007)
- OpenAI (2025) was used to format the references, and generate a first draft of the slides with a prompt like

  ```
  Please make me some slides, based on Chapter 1:
  https://mlpp.pressbooks.pub/writinghandbook/chapter/chapter-1/
  Make them in LaTeX, using luatex and biber, please make around 15
  slides with at least 5 bullet points, use sub-lists where appropriate.
  ```

- **Claude Opus 5** (Anthropic, 2026) was used to check the slides: to resolve every DOI against Crossref, fetch every URL, and compare each quotation with its original. The prompt was of the form

  ```
  Verify every claim, DOI, URL and quotation against a real source. Where you cannot
  verify something, say so rather than guessing --- never invent a reference.
  ```

Acknowledgements II

Each correction names the source it was checked against. Responsibility for what remains is mine.

References I

芥川龍之介. (1918). 蜘蛛の糸 Kumo no ito [The Spider's Thread]. 赤い鳥 *Akai Tori*, *1*(1).

Allosso, D., & Allosso, S. F. (2019). *A short handbook for writing essays in the humanities and social sciences*. Minnesota Libraries Publishing Project. https://mlpp.pressbooks.pub/writinghandbook/

Anthropic. (2026). *Claude Opus 5 (Sep 20, 2026 version)* (Large language model). Retrieved September 20, 2026, from https://claude.ai/

Čapek, K. (1936). *Válka s Mloky [War with the Newts]*. Fr. Borový.

Krause, S. D. (2007). *The process of research writing*. https://www.stevendkrause.com/tprw/

Mytton, D. (2021). Data centre water consumption. *npj Clean Water*, *4*(1), 11. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41545-021-00101-w

OpenAI. (2025). *ChatGPT (Mar 14, 2025 version)* (Large language model). Retrieved October 14, 2025, from https://chat.openai.com/

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Reid, E. S. (2024). *Rethinking your writing: Rhetoric for reflective writers* [Website: https://esreid.com/rethink/]. The WAC Clearinghouse; University Press of Colorado. https://doi.org/10.37514/PRA-B.2024.2265

Appendix

These frames are here for reference: they repeat material from another session, or go further than we had time for.

Evaluating Sources — Why It Matters

- Academic writing depends on **credible evidence**.
- Poor sources weaken even the best reasoning.
- Evaluating sources ensures:
  - Accuracy and reliability
  - Awareness of bias and limits
  - Relevance to your argument
- Evaluation is a **critical thinking skill**, not a checklist exercise.

Adapted from Evaluating Sources (WAC Clearinghouse, Colorado State University).

Purpose and Audience

- Ask: Why was this text created? For whom?
- Purposes may include:
  - Informing or teaching
  - Persuading or advocating
  - Selling or entertaining
- Identify intended audience: scholars, professionals, or the general public.
- Match the source's aim with your own research goal.

Author and Authority

- Who is the author, and what makes them credible?
- Check:
  - Education and institutional affiliation
  - Prior publications and expertise
  - Reputation in the field
- Anonymous or uncredentialed authors demand extra scrutiny.
- Authority may also stem from collective or institutional authorship.

Publisher and Venue

- Who publishes or hosts the source?
- University presses and peer-reviewed journals usually signal quality control.
- For websites, assess the domain and hosting organization.
- Recognize potential **institutional bias** in think tanks, corporations, or advocacy groups.
- Prefer sources with transparent editorial oversight.

Currency and Timeliness

- Consider when the source was written or updated.
- In fast-moving fields, information may age quickly.
- For historical or theoretical work, older sources may remain foundational.
- Look for revision dates, update logs, or newer editions.
- Always relate publication date to your topic's context.
- Has the paper been **retracted**?
  - Search in the official Retraction Watch Database
  - Run a search by title, DOI, author, or journal.
  - This is the most comprehensive open database of retracted papers, maintained by Retraction Watch and made openly available through Crossref.
  - It also notes the reason for retraction (e.g., plagiarism, data falsification, honest error).

Evidence and Support

- Reliable sources **show their work**.
- Ask:
  - What kinds of evidence are used? (data, quotations, examples)
  - Are sources cited and traceable?
  - Is reasoning logical and transparent?
- Unsupported claims or missing citations signal weakness.
- Cross-check evidence against other reputable works.
  - Multiple sources are more reliable

Bias and Objectivity

- No source is completely neutral.
- Look for:
  - Loaded language or emotional tone
  - Selective omission of evidence
  - Conflicts of interest or funding ties
- Identify perspective; judge how it shapes interpretation.
- Acknowledge bias rather than ignoring it.

Balance and Completeness

- Does the source present multiple viewpoints fairly?
- Recognize one-sided or partial presentations.
  - If they cite mostly themselves it is a bad sign (what counts as “too much” varies a lot by field)
  - If they only cite their colleagues it is a bad sign
- Check whether evidence contradicting the claim is addressed.
- Balanced sources strengthen your own credibility when cited.
- Even biased sources can be useful if analyzed critically.

Relevance to Your Project

- Determine how the source connects to your research question.
- Directly relevant sources:
  - Support or challenge your thesis
  - Provide key evidence or theory
- Peripheral sources may supply context or background.
- Avoid citing tangential material to inflate your bibliography.

Primary vs. Secondary Sources

- **Primary:** original materials (texts, data, interviews, artifacts).
- **Secondary:** analysis, interpretation, commentary.
- **Tertiary:** index or textual consolidation of primary and secondary sources
- Choose according to purpose:
  - Primary for direct evidence
  - Secondary for framing and critique
  - Tertiary for an overview
- Distinguish between firsthand and filtered perspectives.

Scholarly vs. Popular Sources

- **Scholarly:** peer-reviewed, technical, detailed references.
- **Popular:** general readership, journalistic style.
- Use scholarly works for evidence, popular for public context.
- Be cautious: some “grey literature” mixes the two.
- Evaluate tone, citations, and rigor to tell them apart.

Checklist for Evaluating a Source

- Purpose and audience clearly stated?
- Author's credentials and affiliations verifiable?
- Publisher or host credible and transparent?
- Evidence traceable and balanced?
- Date current enough for the topic?
- Bias recognized and context considered?
- Source relevant to your own argument?

Integrating Sources

- Use quotation, paraphrase, and summary effectively.
- Cite sources to:
  - Credit others' ideas
  - Strengthen your credibility
  - Help readers locate materials
- Follow the style your community uses — APA 7 in this course.
- Blend sources seamlessly with your own analysis.